New York as his country's ambassador to the UN. Within a few years, the position of the secretary-general fell vacant due to an air crash that killed the incumbent Dag Hammarskjöld. The Great Powers agreed on only one name as the replacement—U Thant.

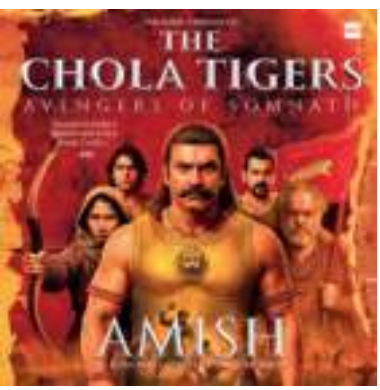
What worked in his favour was the decisive emergence of the vision of Afro-Asian unity, forged at Bandung in 1955, and formalised at the first conference of the Non-Aligned Movement in Belgrade in 1961. When U Thant spoke and acted, he had in mind the collective interests of the Third World as part of the larger global family. What also helped him was his Asian mindset. He aptly described himself as "a conservative Buddhist who valued modesty, humility, love, a live-and-let-live attitude" and, above all, "understanding the other man's point of view".

The volume has been crafted with dexterity and imagination. It reads like a novel, opening with a scene featuring former Beatle John Lennon in a "brown polka jacket" at a fancy New York hotel and closing on a sombre note, pinpointing how (and why) the Burmese diplomat's name disappeared from the histories of the Cuban missile crisis, Vietnam War and Arab-Israel hostilities—the episodes in which Thant played a substantial role. The chapters on Cuba, Indo-China and the Middle East provide valuable material for future researchers.

The fact that Thant's **grandson, a talented historian and writer, authored this book** lends it special poignancy

The fact that Thant's grandson, a talented historian and writer, authored this book lends it special poignancy. His Burmese sensitivity enables him to paint a convincing portrait of an extraordinary man and his challenging times. Gen Z will undoubtedly benefit from reading it. ■

—Rajiv Bhatia



BOOKS ▼

RECLAIMING HISTORY

Amish's new audiobook *The Chola Tigers* brings his mythic reimagining of Indian history to life with vivid detail

Audible India recently released the audiobook version of Amish's latest novel, *The Chola Tigers: Avengers of Somnath*. The novel (published by HarperCollins India) is the second instalment of Amish's 'Indic Chronicles' series of books, after *Legend of Suheldev: The King Who Saved India* (2020), which is also available on Audible. The audiobook has been divided into 28 chapters and is narrated by Vijayan Menon. Speaking about his latest project, Amish says, "With *The Chola Tigers*, I wanted to correct a misconception that is unfortunately widespread among Indian readers, thanks to colonial historians—that our ancestors only lost battles for a thousand years, this stereotype that they were weak, cowardly vegetarians. In this book, I wanted to show that, actually, our ancestors were the toughest guys of their era."

In *The Chola Tigers*, a group of five individuals, led by Emperor Rajendra Chola, make the arduous trek to the kingdom of Mahmud of Ghazni, in order to retrieve a shivalinga stolen during Mahmud's raid on the Somnath Temple. Compared to Amish's previous novels, there is a great deal of hardcore warcraft explored within these pages—fighting techniques, the manufacture and upkeep of weapons, et cetera receive a lot of attention and an impressive degree of technical detail. The action scenes are brutal and fast-paced, and the deaths of important characters receive protracted, appropriately dramatic treatment.

A GROUP OF FIVE INDIVIDUALS LED BY **EMPEROR RAJENDRA CHOLA MAKE THE ARDUOUS TREK** TO THE KINGDOM OF MAHMUD OF GHAZNI, TO RETRIEVE A STOLEN SHIVALINGA

During these past few years, Amish has expanded his authorial empire into other media as well. Earlier this year, he hosted the Discovery show *Legends of Shiva with Amish*. He became the co-founder of a gaming company, Tara, earlier this year. According to Amish, this is the natural evolution of his storytelling. "Every medium has its own strengths and weaknesses," he says. "But we have seen that people today want some relief from screen time because our eyes get fatigued. So, in that kind of scenario, audiobooks are so useful. You can follow the story while you are driving, cooking, whatever. I think it's a fantastic medium and I am glad my books will get a new generation of readers this way." ■

—Aditya Mani Jha